

PROTECTIVE PARENT

CITIPATI MOTHER

When several remarkable specimens of *Citipati* (a type of feathered dinosaur called an oviraptorosaur) were found with their eggs, experts made a link between these brooding dinosaurs and similar nesting behavior of modern birds. More recently, however, scientists have begun to question this idea. The discovery of intact *Citipati* fossil nests that contained pairs of eggs arranged in three to four circles with a clear center was unlike anything seen in modern animals.

A long, flexible neck allowed *Citipati* to keep an eye out for predators in the distance.

Sitting tight

This cast of a *Citipati* in a nest shows how it laid its eggs in a circle with enough space for a parent to sit comfortably in the middle. Although this nest has 22 eggs, most complete nests have at least 30 eggs in them. Some scientists suggest that this specimen may be the father sitting with the eggs to protect them, while others think that it may be a mother who had not yet finished laying all her eggs when she died.

AT A GLANCE

YEAR OF DISCOVERY	1993
PLACE	Gobi Desert, Mongolia
FOUND BY	Mark Norell and team
LIVED	75–71 MYA



The neck and skull of this *Citipati* were lost in the original fossil and later added on in the cast.

A small, hollow crest on *Citipati*'s skull was similar to the crests on modern-day cassowaries.

